# My Childhood

## The big idea

In this extract from his autobiography ***Wings of Fire***, **Dr A. P. J. Abdul Kalam** (former President of India and missile scientist) remembers growing up in **Rameswaram, Tamil Nadu**. He describes a simple, secure home and a society where Hindus and Muslims lived in harmony, and a few people who tried to divide them and were corrected.

## Family and home

- He was born into a middle-class **Tamil Muslim** family. His father **Jainulabdeen** was neither educated nor rich but was generous, wise and disciplined. His mother **Ashiamma** was kind; she fed more outsiders every day than family members.
- They lived in an **ancestral house** built in the mid-nineteenth century on Mosque Street. Kalam inherited **honesty and self-discipline** from his father and **faith in goodness and deep kindness** from his mother.

## The war and his first earnings

- When **World War II** broke out in **1939**, there was a sudden demand for **tamarind seeds**; Kalam collected and sold them to earn a little money.
- The train stopped halting at Rameswaram, so newspapers were thrown from the moving train. His cousin **Samsuddin** gave him the job of catching the bundles, and Kalam earned his **first wages**, which made him proud.

## Friends and secular upbringing

- His three close friends were **Ramanadha Sastry, Aravindan and Sivaprakasan**, all from orthodox Hindu families. They never felt any difference of religion.
- His mother and grandmother told him stories from the **Ramayana** and the life of the Prophet.

## Three incidents about prejudice

1. **The new teacher**: In class five, a new teacher could not stand a Muslim boy (wearing a cap) sitting with **Ramanadha Sastry**, son of the temple priest, and sent Kalam to the back bench. **Pakshi Lakshmana Sastry** (Ramanadha's father, high priest of the Rameswaram temple) summoned the teacher and told him to apologise or leave the island. The teacher regretted and reformed.
2. **The science teacher**: **Sivasubramania Iyer**, an orthodox Brahmin, invited Kalam home for a meal. His wife refused to serve a Muslim boy in her kitchen. Iyer **served Kalam himself** and invited him again the next week; this time his wife served Kalam inside the kitchen. Iyer said that when you want to change the system, you have to confront such problems.
3. **Leaving home**: Kalam wanted to study at **Ramanathapuram**, the district headquarters. His father gave permission, quoting **Khalil Gibran** that children are not their parents' possessions but have their own thoughts.

**THEME**

**Secularism and social harmony**: prejudice exists, but wise and courageous people can overcome it.

**WHO REBUKED THE NEW TEACHER?**

It was Pakshi Lakshmana Sastry (the priest), not Sivasubramania Iyer. Iyer is the science teacher who invited Kalam for a meal.

**LIKELY QUESTIONS**

What qualities did Kalam inherit from his parents? How did he earn his first wages? How did Sivasubramania Iyer change his wife? Why did the new teacher's behaviour shock the children? Value points: tolerance, courage to change, humble beginnings.

## Quick recap

- Rameswaram; father Jainulabdeen, mother Ashiamma.
- 1939 war: tamarind seeds, newspaper bundles with Samsuddin.
- Friends of different faiths; prejudice corrected by Lakshmana Sastry and Sivasubramania Iyer.

## Practice questions

1. "My Childhood" is taken from Kalam's autobiography
   (a) Ignited Minds (b) Wings of Fire (c) India 2020 (d) My Journey
2. Which commodity suddenly came into demand at the start of World War II?
   (a) Rice (b) Coconuts (c) Tamarind seeds (d) Fish
3. Who helped Kalam earn his first wages?
   (a) His father (b) His cousin Samsuddin (c) Ramanadha Sastry (d) Ahmed Jallaluddin
4. Who rebuked the new teacher for separating Kalam and Ramanadha?
   (a) Pakshi Lakshmana Sastry (b) Sivasubramania Iyer (c) Jainulabdeen (d) The headmaster
5. What did Sivasubramania Iyer do when his wife refused to serve Kalam?
   (a) He sent Kalam home (b) He scolded his wife in front of guests (c) He cancelled the meal (d) He served Kalam food himself
6. Whom did Kalam's father quote when allowing him to leave Rameswaram?
   (a) Rabindranath Tagore (b) Mahatma Gandhi (c) Khalil Gibran (d) Swami Vivekananda
7. What qualities did Kalam inherit from his parents?
8. "My Childhood" shows how individuals can change society's attitudes. Explain with reference to two incidents.

Answers: 1. b 2. c 3. b 4. a 5. d 6. c 7. see notes 8. see notes